

POLITICIAN AND ABOLITIONIST Born 1759 Died 1833

William Wilberforce

“We are all guilty... in this wretched business.”

WILLIAM WILBERFORCE, SPEECH TO THE HOUSE OF COMMONS, 1789

The third of four children born into a well-to-do Yorkshire family, Wilberforce grew up in an age when the institution of slavery was considered socially acceptable. He attended Hull Grammar School, in northern England, and from 1768 was brought up by an uncle who introduced him to Methodism, an offshoot of the Church of England. In 1776 he entered St. John's College, Cambridge. Before graduating he decided on a career in politics and fell in with William Pitt the Younger, later British prime minister. Wilberforce returned to Hull in the fall of 1779, running as an independent candidate, and won the parliamentary seat at a personal cost of over £8,000 (\$34,000).

An evangelical parliamentarian

Between 1784–85, Wilberforce began a period of intense religious reflection. He consulted John Newton, rector of St. Mary Woolnoth, London, a former sailor who became an antislavery campaigner thanks to his early experiences as a slave ship master. Wilberforce became a fervent supporter of evangelical Christianity, joining the “Clapham Saints” under John Venn. In the spring of 1786 he returned to the

House of Commons (the elected house of the British Parliament) committed to God, and eager to target immorality and vice. In 1787 he moved to Bath, in western England, where his interest first arose in championing the cause of black African slaves, but, contrary to popular accounts, he was not a founder member of the London Committee for the Abolition of the Slave Trade, and he attended no meetings until June 1791. In 1787 he declined the committee's request to represent the cause in Parliament, and only later agreed to the job “if no one else could be found.”

He once made a pithy observation that “the first years that I was in Parliament I did nothing to any good purpose;

Member of Parliament

William Wilberforce portrayed at a time when he was regularly suffering defeats in the House of Commons at the hands of the powerful lobby of West Indies plantation owners.

St. John's College, Cambridge

The Second Court of St. John's College, Cambridge, where Wilberforce enrolled as an undergraduate in 1776. Here William Pitt the Younger (1759–1806), who himself later became British prime minister, inspired Wilberforce to enter politics.



my own distinction was my darling object.” It was not unknown for him to be on his feet for up to three hours, making speeches to Parliament, for which he was dubbed the “nightingale of the Commons.” His ideal of Christian charity did not always extend to his rivals, and he snubbed the real workhorse of the abolition movement, Thomas Clarkson, almost until the end of his life.

Spurning advice

In the spring of 1791, ignoring prudent advice, Wilberforce urged the parliament to completely abolish

the slave trade; the confrontation immediately failed. Undeterred, he took a prominent abolitionist role in the Commons debate of April 1792 when he made his famous “Africa! Africa!” speech. This also suffered defeat. Wilberforce doggedly pursued the dream of a total abolition bill each year from 1795–1799, but it was regularly thrown out by the powerful West Indies lobby, representing those with financial interests in the region.

Pitt's government fell early in 1801, replaced by that of Henry Addington. By January 1802, however, Wilberforce had become seriously disillusioned,